FINTECH

# Figure's IPO filing marks Mike Cagney's return to public markets

Connie Loizos — 4:23 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

Figure Technology, a seven-year-old blockchain-based lending company, on Monday filed for an IPO of its Class A common stock on Nasdaq, saying in its IPO paperwork that its revenue rose 22.4% to $191 million in the six months ended June 30, and that it reported a profit of $29 million in the same period, compared with a loss of $13 million a year earlier.

The filing offers a chance at vindication for Figure co-founder Mike Cagney, who previously built SoFi before leaving the personal finance platform in 2017 following sexual harassment allegations. SoFi went public in 2021 via a special purpose acquisition company (SPAC) merger and has done pretty well as a public company — its stock is up over 200% in the past year, and its revenue rose 44% in the second quarter of 2025.

Since its founding in 2018 , Figure has established itself as one of the bigger players in blockchain-based lending, claiming more than 160 partners for its loan origination system and capital marketplace. Figure claims to be the largest non-bank provider of home equity lines of credit.

The company, which Cagney founded with his wife June Ou, uses blockchain technology through its Provenance blockchain to speed along approvals for home equity loans, mortgage refinancing, and student and personal loans.

In May, Figure said it was also expanding into cryptocurrency lending, signing a financing agreement with Victory Park Capital for what Figure described as the industry's first securitized pool of crypto-backed loans. That product allows asset owners to borrow against their Bitcoin and Ethereum holdings with loan-to-value ratios up to 75%.

Terms of that deal with Victory Park were not disclosed.

Cagney has a history of ambitious regulatory moves. As TechCrunch reported in late 2020, during the last days of the first Trump administration, Figure applied for a U.S. national bank charter that would have let it accept uninsured deposits exceeding $250,000 from accredited investors while avoiding traditional FDIC and Federal Reserve oversight. The approach could have established a template for other fintech and retail companies to obtain non-traditional bank charters and offer lucrative financial products while avoiding such oversight, but Figure withdrew its application last year amid broader fintech industry challenges.



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The company has undergone major leadership and organizational changes in the meantime. In April 2024, Figure appointed Michael Tannenbaum, former COO of Brex, as CEO. Tannenbaum previously worked with Cagney as SoFi's chief revenue officer.

And in an unusual corporate maneuver, Cagney spun off Figure Markets in early 2024, creating a standalone digital asset exchange for crypto trading, crypto-backed loans, and stablecoins. But just over a year later, in July, Figure reversed course and smooshed the two entities back together.

The company says the strategy positions it to capture a huge and growing opportunity in real-world asset tokenization. (Real-world asset tokenization involves converting traditional assets like mortgages, real estate, or loans — even art — into digital tokens that can be traded on blockchain networks. Heavyweight financial players like BlackRock and JPMorgan are among those who have recently entered the space.)

It's worth noting that this is not Figure's first attempt at going public. The company previously planned to list via a merger with a SPAC called Figure Acquisition Corp, but the deal got scrapped due to rising interest rates and redemption rates, among other challenges. The blank check company was later delisted from the New York Stock Exchange.

Figure, whose backers include Apollo Global Management and Ribbit Capital, also failed to complete a planned merger with mortgage lender Homebridge Financial Services in 2022, citing regulatory delays 10 months after the tie-up was announced.

The IPO filing is no surprise to industry observers. For one, Figure — which last raised $200 million in 2021 at a $3.2 billion valuation — announced weeks ago that it had filed a confidential statement for an IPO. Further, the timing aligns with a growing wave of crypto-related companies seeking public listings, encouraged by the wildly successful debut of Circle Internet Group back in June, and the Trump administration's full-bodied support for the cryptocurrency sector and related legislation.

Circle's shares soared more than 500% in their first two weeks on the public market. Crypto exchange Bullish has added to the momentum as its shares more than doubled on its first day of trading last week.

On Friday, the Winklevoss twins' crypto exchange Gemini filed for an IPO despite reporting a $282.5 million net loss in the first half of 2025.

Goldman Sachs, Jefferies, and BofA Securities are serving as the lead bookrunners for Figure's IPO. The number of shares to be offered and their price range have not yet been determined.

Topics: crypto Figure Technology Fintech IPO Mike Cagney SoFi

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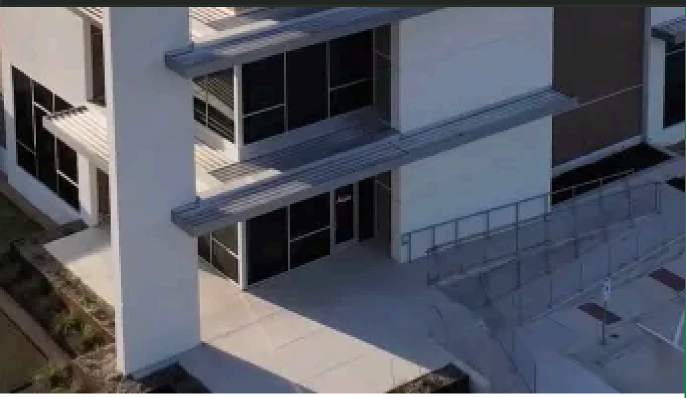

IMAGE CREDITS: AALO ATOMICS

Tim De Chant — 8:41 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Nuclear startups have been soaking up attention from hyperscalers and cash from investors. Aalo

Atomics is the latest beneficiary of the big tech-small nuclear love affair, raising $100 million in a Series B, the company announced today.

The startup plans to flip the switch on its first reactor in the summer of 2026, CEO Matt Loszak said in a LinkedIn post. The facility will be located on the campus of the Idaho National Laboratory.

Aalo — not to be confused with the defunct furniture startup — could be considered a pseudo-spinout of the Department of Energy lab, which developed and open-sourced a small modular reactor design called Marvel. The company's CTO, Yasir Arafat, previously led Marvel's design, which Aalo says "inspired" its prototype. Aalo also received development support from the Idaho National Lab as part of an Obama administration program to accelerate nuclear reactor development.

The Series B round was led by Valor Equity Partners with participation from 50Y, Alumni Ventures, Crescent Enterprises, Crosscut, Fine Structure Ventures, Gaingels, Harpoon Ventures, Hitachi Ventures, Kindred Ventures, MCJ, NRG Energy, Nucleation Capital, Perpetual VC, Tishman Speyer, and Vamos Ventures.

If Aalo can meet its aggressive deadline, it would buck a trend in the nuclear industry, which has a history of long timelines compounded by delays.

Like many advanced nuclear startups, Aalo is counting on economies of scale to help rein in both costs and build times. If the company can prove its approach works, it says it will build thousands of Aalo Pod power plants, which will consist of five Aalo-1 reactors delivering heat to a single turbine to generate a total of 50 megawatts of electricity.

The startup says that the Aalo-X prototype will also have an "experimental" data center built next door, a detail that sounds more like a marketing ploy than a technological innovation.



Ultimately, Aalo says it aims to deliver electricity at three cents per kilowatt-hour, a price that would make it competitive with new natural gas power plants and solar farms built today. The startup hasn't put a timeline on that price, though, a wise move given the nuclear industry's previous promises.

Aalo isn't the only nuclear startup making news this week. Yesterday, Kairos said that the Tennessee Valley Authority agreed to buy 50 megawatts of generating capacity from its Hermes 2 power plant, which the startup is planning to build in Oak Ridge, Tennessee. Google, in turn, will use that power to drive its data centers.

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SECURITY

## US spy chief says UK has dropped its Apple backdoor demand

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

7:25 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

The U.K has dropped its demand for special access to Apple's cloud systems, or a "backdoor," following negotiations with the Trump administration, according to U.S. National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard.

"As a result, the U.K. has agreed to drop its mandate for Apple to provide a 'back door' that would have enabled access to the protected encrypted data of American citizens and encroached on our civil liberties," Gabbard wrote in a post on X. She also claimed that she worked along President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance in the negotiations.

> Over the past few months, I've been working closely with our partners in the UK, alongside @POTUS and @VP, to ensure Americans' private data remains private and our Constitutional rights and civil liberties are protected.
>
> As a result, the UK has agreed to drop its mandate for...
>
> — DNI Tulsi Gabbard (@DNIGabbard) August 19, 2025

This is the latest (and unexpected) development in a months-long saga that saw the British government secretly demanding Apple grant its authorities access — essentially asking for a backdoor — to the encrypted data of iCloud users, effectively anywhere in the world, particularly those who turn on Advanced Data Protection (or ADP), an opt-in security feature. ADP turns on end-to-end encryption for iCloud, meaning only the user can access their files stored on Apple's cloud servers.

The existence of the legal demand was first reported by The Washington Post in February, which was made under the U.K.'s Investigatory Powers Act 2016, also known as the Snoopers' Charter. The request sparked outrage and condemnation from privacy and security experts worldwide, who argued that if the U.K. government obtained what it wanted, it would weaken privacy for the whole world, and also open the door for more governments to make similar demands, even in other companies' technologies.

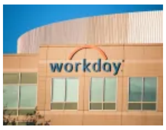
Apple initially responded by removing ADP from the U.K., meaning new users couldn't turn it on. The company also said it would give guidance to existing users who "will eventually need to disable this security feature."

In the meantime, Apple also reportedly challenged the backdoor mandate in court, a case that was initially secret but was then ruled to be held in public.

Apple and the U.K. Home Office, which initiated the demand on behalf of the British government, did not respond to requests for comment.



SECURITY

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Zack Whittaker - 1 day ago

Olivia Coleman, the press secretary of the U.S. Office of the Director of National Intelligence, referred to a February letter to Sen. Wyden and Rep. Biggs.

Apple previously told TechCrunch that the company has "never built a backdoor or master key" to any of its products or services and it "never will."

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